emperor built the White Horse monastery (Bai Ma Si) for them in Luoyang, and that is where they spent the rest of their lives, translating Buddhist scriptures into Chinese. Both are buried at the monastery.

In 2003, Indian Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee visited Luoyang and announced that as a gift to the people of China, India would build a new temple to mark this historical connection between India and China. The temple, based on the Sanchi stupa, was completed in 2010 and was inaugurated by President Pratibha Patil during an official visit to China in May 2016.

Kasyapa Matanga and Dharmaratna became the first of several Indian monks and teachers who travelled to China during the next thousand years to preach Buddhism and to translate into Chinese a vast volume of Buddhist literature, as also texts on astronomy, mathematics, medicine and philosophy. There was also a steady stream of Chinese monks who travelled to India to acquire authentic Buddhist texts, to visit places of pilgrimage, and to study at the ancient monastic universities at Taxila (now in Pakistani Punjab) and Nalanda (in Bihar).

During the first millennium, there were several celebrated centres of Buddhist learning in what is now Afghanistan, and in Central Asia too, in the oasis towns of the region, in particular Khotan, now known as Hetian, in Chinese Xinjiang. Towards the end of the Han dynasty, the term Tianzhu or ‘Heavenly Jewel’ began to be used to describe India. The later Han chronicles specifically state that Shendu and Tianzhu describe the same country, that is, India. In later literature, India came to be described as Xitian or ‘Western Paradise’, or more generally as the western country. Its current appellation as Yindu was used by the well-known Chinese pilgrim of the Tang dynasty, Xuan Zang, who travelled to India in the seventh century CE .

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These early intimations of a country to the west as a centre of high learning and spirituality were in sharp contrast to the attribution of a ‘barbarian’ character to the semi-nomadic tribes inhabiting the steppes along Chinese